
A sustainable training routine

FOUR SESSIONS EACH WEEK

Session A: 25 minutes of a new booklet and ten minutes of recall. Session B: 20 minutes of exercises and 15 minutes of diagram play. Session C: one slow game. Session D: 30-45 minutes reviewing that game and updating one weak branch.

CHOOSE USEFUL TIME CONTROLS

A slower rapid game such as 15+10 or longer gives you time to use a threat checklist. Blitz can test recall, but it should not be your only measure of whether the opening makes sense.

A SMALL REPERTOIRE NOTEBOOK

For each game record the opponent's defense, first unfamiliar move, your candidate moves, your decision and its reason. Add the corrected line only after you understand why the correction matters.

REVIEW INTERVALS

Revisit a new line the next day, three days later, one week later and one month later. If you miss it, shorten the next interval. If you explain it easily, spend the saved time playing the resulting position.

Weeks 1-4

WEEK 1: FOUNDATION AND THE DECISION TREE | BOOKLETS 00, 01, 21

Learn why c4 challenges d5. Rehearse the response to every common first move. Play three slow games and record the first unfamiliar position.

WEEK 2: QUEEN'S GAMBIT DECLINED | BOOKLETS 02, 03

Learn the main Carlsbad line and the triangle exception. Explain the minority attack without moving the pieces, then identify when ...c5 changes the plan.

WEEK 3: QUEEN'S GAMBIT ACCEPTED AND SLAV | BOOKLETS 04, 05

Practice recovering c4 by development. Drill the purpose of a4 against ...b5 and distinguish early from delayed captures on c4.

WEEK 4: SEMI-SLAV AND ISOLATED-PAWN STRUCTURES | BOOKLETS 06, 07, 22

Learn the Meran branching point. Play practice positions with the isolated d-pawn from both sides and annotate which trades help each player.

Weeks 5-8

WEEK 5: ALBIN AND CHIGORIN | BOOKLETS 08, 09

Reconstruct the Albin main line, including en passant. Recognize the Lasker trap. In the Chigorin, explain what you receive for doubled pawns.

WEEK 6: OTHER QUEEN-PAWN COUNTERS | BOOKLETS 10, 18

Practice Baltic, Marshall, Budapest and Blumenfeld recognition. Identify the exact check or capture that changes your normal developing scheme.

WEEK 7: QUEEN'S INDIAN AND BOGO | BOOKLETS 11, 12

Distinguish ...Ba6 from ...Bb7. Rehearse the Bogo check response. Explain the e4 battle and avoid unnecessary queen moves.

WEEK 8: KING'S INDIAN AND GRUNFELD | BOOKLETS 14, 15

Use the fianchetto consistently while distinguishing ...d6 from ...d5. Start practice games from the final main-line diagrams.

Weeks 9-12

WEEK 9: BENONI AND BENKO | BOOKLETS 16, 17

Learn the d5 space advantage and Black's ...b5 break. Practice the 5.b6 Benko route and the different Blumenfeld move order.

WEEK 10: DUTCH AND FLEXIBLE DEFENSES | BOOKLETS 19, 20

Name Leningrad, Stonewall and Classical structures from the pawns. Explain why 2.g3 is a choice, not a claim that 2.c4 loses.

WEEK 11: MIDDLEGAME HANDOFF | BOOKLETS 22, 23

For each training position, write two candidate moves and Black's plan before reading the continuation. Review your own recurring structural mistakes.

WEEK 12: ASSESSMENT AND CONSOLIDATION | BOOKLETS 24, 25

Take the mixed test without notes. Revisit only missed branches. Optional: begin Booklet 13 if you want to add the Nimzo-Indian to your repertoire.

Reference card: the first decisions

AGAINST 1...D5

2.c4. ...e6: QGD; ...c6: Slav; ...dxc4: Accepted; ...e5: Albin; ...Nc6: Chigorin. Develop according to the actual defense.

AGAINST 1...NF6

2.c4. ...e6: 3.Nf3 and identify QGD/Queen's Indian/Bogo/Benoni. ...g6: 3.Nf3 and the fianchetto family. ...c5: d5. ...e5: dxe5.

WHEN C4 WAITS

Against ...e5 play dxe5; against ...f5 choose g3; against ...c5 or ...Nc6 choose d5; against ...b6 or ...b5 choose e4. See Booklet 01 for the distinction between necessity and preference.

THE ALBIN CARD

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 d4 4.Nf3 Nc6 5.Nbd2. Think Nb3 against d4. Against ...Bg4 account for the pin; against ...Nge7 know the e4 and queen-trade idea. Do not enter the Lasker trap with automatic e3.

THE THREAT CARD

Before every move: checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, central break, worst piece. Before every recapture: is there an intermediate check or stronger capture?

Your post-game review form

GAME DETAILS

Date: _____ Opponent: _____

Time control: _____ Defense: _____

Result: _____ Booklet / line ID: _____

FIRST UNFAMILIAR POSITION

Move number: _____

What did Black threaten? _____

My candidate moves: _____

What I played and why: _____

WHAT THE GAME TAUGHT ME

Opening decision to repair: _____

Structural plan I misunderstood: _____

Tactical pattern I missed: _____

One position to replay from both sides: _____

NEXT REVIEW

My corrected explanation in one sentence: _____

Review dates: tomorrow _____ three days _____ one week _____